GARDEN CITY CHURCH

USHER MINISTRY MANUAL

Serving with Honor · Guiding with Grace



Ministry Overview

PURPOSE

The Usher Ministry exists to create a welcoming, orderly, and supportive worship environment, ensuring every guest and attendee feels valued, assisted, and cared for from the moment they step onto the property.

MISSION

To serve the congregation with excellence, hospitality, and spiritual maturity, supporting the flow of services and maintaining an environment where worship can happen freely and without distraction.

CORE SCRIPTURE

“Offer hospitality to one another without grumbling.” — 1 Peter 4:9

The Role of An Usher

Ushers are frontline ministers of hospitality. Their responsibilities include:

- *Greeting and welcoming attendees
- Directing people where they need to go
- Supporting the Landing Team and Security Team
- Assisting those with special needs
- Managing the seating flow
- Monitoring the sanctuary environment
- Handling practical needs (lights, spills, facility issues)
- Responding to discomfort, disorder, or disruptions
- Guiding the congregation during transitions (altar, communion, events)
- Acting as pastoral support during service flow

Ushers do NOT perform security duties, but they must know when to call Security.

Team Structure

USHER MINISTRY DIRECTOR

- Coordinates training, scheduling, and service flow support.

TEAM LEADS

- Assign positions, handle communication, manage special events.

USHERS

- Serve in rotation, provide hospitality, maintain order and assistance.

Cooperation With Landing Team

The Landing Team focuses on **initial guest touch-points**.

USHERS SUPPORT BY:

- Guiding guests after initial greeting
- Helping direct first-time visitors to kids' check-in, bathrooms, coffee area, sanctuary
- Ensuring seamless handoff between Landing Team and seating ushers
- Alerting Landing Team to new or overwhelmed guests needing extra time
- Supporting follow-up moments (visitor cards, seating assistance)

Ushers and Landing Team are two wings of one ministry of welcome.

Onboarding Process

INVITATION

A personal invitation to serve.

INTERVIEW

Review:

- Expectations
- Hospitality culture
- Service flow
- Facility responsibilities
- Requirement to complete Following Jesus

BACKGROUND CHECK/CORI

Mandatory as you work directly with families and vulnerable individuals.

TRAINING & SHADOWING

Hands-on training covering:

- Facility walkthrough
- Sanctuary layout
- HVAC/light switch locations
- Emergency procedures
- Seating strategies
- Hospitality posture
- Securing aisles and emergency exits

SCHEDULE PLACEMENT

Added to Planning Center once fully trained.

Station Responsibilities

PARKING LOT

- Welcome with warmth
- Direct families to entrances
- Assist elderly or disabled attendees
- Alert ushers/security if help is needed

LOBBY/WELCOME AREA

- Greet with eye contact and a smile
- Direct people to children's check-in, restrooms, coffee
- Maintain cleanliness and order
- Quickly respond to spills or messes

SANCTUARY

- Help seat families, latecomers, first-time guests
- Keep aisles clear
- Control distractions
- Watch for discomfort, medical needs, emotional distress
- Guide people during ministry moments (altar response, communion, etc.)

CHILDREN'S WING ASSISTANCE

- Point parents to check-in
- DO NOT allow unauthorized access
- Security handles access control, but ushers support flow and redirect visitors

Facility Responsibility & Practical Skills

LIGHTS

Ushers must know:

- Where sanctuary, lobby, and hallway light switches are
- How to adjust lighting during service if needed (with pastoral permission)

HVAC

Ushers must know:

- Where thermostats are located
- How to adjust settings properly (no rapid temperature swings)
- Who to contact if something seems off

Never change settings without confirming with the Service Director or Pastor on Duty.

CLEANLINESS & HAZARD RESPONSE

Ushers handle:

- Spills
- Trash overflow
- Bio-hazard situations (vomit, blood, etc.)

For Bio-hazards:

- Block off area
- Notify facility lead or team lead
- Use proper cleaning supplies
- Sanitize thoroughly

ROOM AWARENESS

Ushers must keep an eye on:

- Temperature
- Noise level
- Aisle blockages
- Disruptive conversations
- Medical distress
- Overflow crowds
- Visitors who look lost

Hospitality & Service Culture

Ushers must embody:

- Warmth
- Patience
- Professionalism
- Respect
- Kindness
- Calmness under pressure
- Spirit-led discernment

Your voice, posture, and presence set the tone for the service experience.

Handling Disruptions & Rowdiness

Ushers are first responders to order, not security.

When Ushers Intervene:

- Talking or disruption during service
- Rowdy teens
- Children running in unsafe areas
- Someone needing assistance or redirection

Ushers must:

- Approach calmly and quietly
- Use short, gentle phrases
- Avoid embarrassment or escalation
- Only involve Security when necessary
- Deescalate potentially volatile situations

When to Transition to Security
Immediately turn over the situation when:

- Person becomes aggressive
- Behavior becomes threatening
- There is a medical emergency
- Person attempts to enter restricted areas
- Person refuses usher direction
- Someone appears intoxicated or unstable.

Ushers are shepherds of ***order*** - Security handles ***protection.***

Communication & Walkie Talkie Basics

Ushers using walkie-talkies must know:

- Keep radio on lowest necessary volume
- Speak clearly, briefly
- No unnecessary chatter
- Use channel assigned for ushers
- Notify Security ONLY when needed

Sample Phrases:

- "Usher to Security, assistance needed in lobby."
- "Usher team, need seating support front left."
- "Facilities request: spill near coffee area."

Special Needs Assistance

Ushers must be ready to support:

- Wheelchairs
- Canes/walkers
- Elderly individuals
- Parents with strollers
- Visually impaired
- Individuals overwhelmed by noise or crowds

Always offer:

- Arm support
- Preferred seating
- Extra space
- Friendly reassurance
- Never force assistance — always offer gently.

Service Flow Responsibilities

Before Service

- Walk facility
- Turn on lights (as necessary)
- Ensure aisles are clear
- Prepare seating layout
- Make sure offering baskets or communion materials are ready

After Service

- Assist with crowd flow
- Clean sanctuary and lobby areas
- Return offering materials
- Turn off lights
- Reset chairs if needed

During Service

- Remain attentive
- Assist latecomers
- Protect the atmosphere
- Support transitions (altar, communion, baptisms, etc.)

Safety & Emergency Cooperation

Ushers must know:

- All building exits
- Evacuation routes
- Where first aid supplies are
- Where AED is located
- Who Security Team Lead is

During Emergencies - Ushers support by:

- Guiding people
- Keeping calm
- Helping elderly and families
- Clearing aisles
- Directing crowds to exits
- Supporting children's wing leaders

Code of Conduct

Ushers are expected to:

- Dress neatly
- Maintain punctuality
- Serve with a smile
- Never argue with attendees
- Never leave their post without permission
- Maintain confidentiality
- Uphold respect toward pastors and staff
- Support the mission: Live the Life. Tell the Story.

Ongoing Training

Ushers will be refreshed annually on:

- Hospitality practices
- Sanctuary flow
- Emergency response
- Cooperation with Landing & Security Teams
- Modern safety and facility updates